

station one of their employees in the corridor of the exchange so that they could alert their offices about important announcements.

The trading ring was on the first floor. Outside both the first and second floors were huge blackboards on which an employee of the stock exchange would write down the prices of the most actively traded stocks, updating them every thirty minutes. The official would collate the prices by talking to the main brokers and jobbers to find out what prices they had bought or sold for. After he had updated the prices on the blackboard, he would trade places with his colleague who had been broadcasting the prices. That official would then head for the ring and update the blackboard after half an hour.

Around half past five in the evening, the stock exchange would publish the '*bhav* copy', a report listing the high, low and closing prices of the stocks traded that day. It was not done very scientifically, but it was broadly reliable. Its compilation was done by means of a stock exchange official collecting the prices by talking to the brokers and jobbers, and checking their *sauda* pads (which were issued by BSE and bore its stamp) if necessary.

The stock exchange issued only a limited number of *bhav* copies, so there was always a scramble to get them. Some ingenious players found a way to profit from this by taking photocopies of the *bhav* copy and selling them outside the stock exchange for a few rupees.

After trading hours there operated an unofficial market for some of the more liquid stocks. This was called the kerb market and, true to its name, the dealings were conducted on the street outside the stock exchange. The prices in the kerb market would be at a premium or discount based on the closing prices on the stock exchange, depending on the sentiment and events. There were players who specialized in kerb market deals and did not trade much in the regular market. When they did deal in the regular market, it was mostly to put through the trades that were struck over the phone or on the kerb the previous day.

The specialist kerb traders had their representatives on the street where the business was transacted, taking orders from clients. Right outside the erstwhile Lalit Restaurant on Ambalal Doshi Marg, parallel to Dalal Street, was where the kerb deals were conducted. Activity on the kerb would rise to a feverish pitch during market-moving events. During such times, it was